SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #7 · RACE, ETHNICITY AND LANGUAGE

# “People like me don't succeed.”

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## Where it often comes from

If we see few examples of people from our background in leadership, college, or business, we may conclude that success is for others. Counselors, teachers, or relatives may have lowered expectations, and the statistics we hear can feel like a sentence.

## What Scripture teaches

Scripture is full of unlikely people chosen by God: Joseph the slave, Ruth the foreigner, Esther the orphan, David the youngest son. Paul writes, “God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong.” He also says, “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.” Group statistics describe averages, not individuals. Your future is not determined by where people like you have been.

> *“But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong”* (1 Corinthians 1:27).

## Also see

> “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:13).

> “Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will be stationed in the presence of kings; he will not stand before obscure men” (Proverbs 22:29).

> “For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope” (Jeremiah 29:11).

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

## Common self-statements

- Nobody from my background makes it.
- I will hit a ceiling.
- I do not look like the people who succeed.
- Trying is a waste.
- They will not give me a chance.
- I should not expect much.

## Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Treating group averages as personal destiny.
- Fortune telling: Predicting failure.
- Mental filter: Noticing the failures and missing the successes.
- Labeling: Letting a category define me.

## Challenging questions

- Who from my background has succeeded, in any field?
- Who told me people like me do not succeed?

- What strengths and experiences do I bring that others lack?
- What barriers are real, and what can I do about them?
- What does God say about the people He chooses?
- What is one concrete next step?

## Truth summary

> Group statistics do not decide my future. God often chooses the unlikely, and He gives strength for the road. Real barriers exist, and I can face them with preparation, allies, and perseverance.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Faith
- Will of God
- Hopeless
- Strength

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Unemployment

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Greater** — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

**More Than Conquerors** — Steven Curtis Chapman
Christ's saving work answers condemnation, shame, and fear of separation from God.

**Already There** — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

**Great Is Thy Faithfulness** — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "People like me don't succeed"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"People like me don't succeed." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Who from my background has succeeded?
- ☐ Who told me I cannot?
- ☐ What strengths do I have?
- ☐ What barriers are real?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ God chooses the unlikely.
- ☐ I can do all things through Christ.
- ☐ Skilled work stands out.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ Barriers are real and can be faced.
- ☐ My future is not decided by averages.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 1:27
  *"But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong."*
- ☐ Philippians 4:13
  *"I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."*
- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  *"I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Evidence of possibility: Each week, add one example of someone like you who succeeded.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, 1 Corinthians 1:27 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God chooses the unlikely, and I can do all things through Christ.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- [ ] Collect examples. Find three people from your background who succeeded.
- [ ] Find a mentor. Ask someone further down the road to talk.
- [ ] Name a goal. Write one specific goal and the next step.
- [ ] Name barriers and allies. List what stands in the way and who can help.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People like me don't succeed": _____ % My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Possibility seen |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People like me don't succeed.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, You choose the unlikely. Lift my eyes beyond what I have been told. Give me strength, doors, and allies, and use my story for Your glory. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*